By Blade and Oath

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/63014488.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Comedy, Angst and Humor, Oblivious Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Denial of Feelings, Embarrassment, Courting Rituals, Love Confessions, Public Display of Affection, Kind Of, Misunderstandings

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-02-13 Words: 7,932 Chapters: 1/1

By Blade and Oath

by Lunaeryi

Summary

In which Mydei realizes Phainon is in love with him and naturally like any sane person, goes through the five stages of grief before accepting it and beating the crap out of Phainon, kissing him, and walking away.

Phainon did not sign up for this.

Notes

Did I say I was gonna write short fics now? Pffttt you can throw that down the gutter now😭

This was something that was supposed to be like 3k at most until my other fic marinated enough comments for me to decide what fic to write next (Stuck in a box is winning) but it kind of went down from there, AS YOU CAN SEE😭😭

See the end of the work for more notes

It was supposed to be a quiet afternoon—nothing more than a break in the training grounds. The sun hung low in the sky, lazily casting long shadows across the dusty floor. Mydei sat against a stone pillar, arms folded, eyes half-lidded, exuding the kind of stillness that made lesser men wary of approaching.

The usual chaos of Okhema unfolded around him. The clash of steel, the bark of commands, the thud of bodies hitting the dirt—it all blended into the background. None of it concerned him. He was not in the mood to deal with people today.

Naturally, someone was about to make that his problem.

“Mydei,” a voice called from behind.

He didn’t bother turning. Whoever it was, they weren’t important enough to warrant his attention.

“If you’re about to waste my time, rethink it,” he said, tone flat, yet carrying enough weight that most men would have taken it as a warning. “I’m not interested in your latest failure, Gaius. Or whatever disaster you call a love life.”

Gaius, the captain of the training squad, let out a short laugh, but there was an edge of nervousness to it. “Not that. It’s about Phainon.”

Mydei’s brow twitched.

Of course it was.

Phainon was always lingering at the edges of his life, like a storm on the horizon that refused to break. Always present. Always watching. Always getting in *his way.*

“What about him?” Mydei asked, voice devoid of any real interest—but his grip on his forearm tightened, betraying something he couldn’t quite name.

Gaius hesitated, which was smart. Unfortunately, he chose to speak anyway.

“Don’t act like you don’t know,” he said, too casual for his own good. “Everyone in the city does.”

Mydei slowly turned his head, finally giving him his full attention. Gaius shifted on his feet. Smart, again.

“I don’t waste my time with gossip,” Mydei said. “Say what you mean, or leave.”

Gaius smiled—nervous now, as if realizing too late that he was standing in the blast zone. “Phainon’s been in love with you for years.”

Silence.

The kind that wasn’t just absence of sound, but a vacuum where sound *should* have been. The kind of silence that stretched, weighed, *threatened*.

Mydei blinked once. Slowly. Then his lips pressed into a thin line as he regarded Gaius with the kind of look one might give a particularly stupid foot soldier who had just fumbled their sword in the middle of a duel.

“Excuse me?”

Gaius, either brave or suicidal, shrugged. “It’s obvious. The guy follows you around like a shadow. Everyone knows.”

Another pause.

Mydei didn’t move. He didn’t react. But the atmosphere around him changed. The air felt heavier. The sounds of training in the background seemed to dull, as if the world itself was bracing for impact.

Then, after an excruciating beat, he exhaled through his nose—slow, measured. Dangerous.

“I don’t have time for this,” he said, standing.

Gaius took a step back.

He tried to cover it, shifting his weight as if it were just a casual adjustment, but Mydei saw it. He always saw it.

“Damn,” Gaius muttered, trying for humor. “Didn’t think you’d take it *that* badly.”

Mydei didn’t dignify that with a response. Instead, his gaze swept across the training yard—just a glance, instinct more than anything—only to land, as if drawn by some unseen force, on *him*.

Phainon.

The bastard stood effortlessly poised in the sun, his sword glinting as he knocked his opponent to the ground with a move so fluid it bordered on arrogant. He barely looked like he was trying.

And then, as if he could *feel* Mydei’s eyes on him, Phainon turned.

For a fraction of a second—so brief it might have been imagined—his expression shifted. Just the slightest flicker of something, before smoothing into his usual unreadable calm.

It was *that* look.

The one Mydei had ignored for years.

And suddenly—against all logic, against all reason—his mind was racing.

The way Phainon always stood too close. The way he never quite let anyone else get between them. The way his presence lingered, persistent, deliberate, like something carefully maintained just beneath the surface.

The way he looked at Mydei sometimes, like he was waiting for something.

And Mydei—*Mydei*—hadn’t seen it.

No.

No, no, no.

This wasn’t happening. This was a joke. A bad one. A mistake.

He must have taken a harder hit to the head than he thought.

“Gaius,” he said, voice dangerously soft. “Leave.”

Gaius, wisely, left.

But the thought had already rooted itself in Mydei’s mind, and no amount of willpower could tear it free.

Phainon’s been in love with you for years.

Impossible.

Ridiculous.

And yet—

Mydei turned on his heel, ready to leave, to do *something* that didn’t involve standing here drowning in intrusive thoughts.

And then, because the universe despised him, Phainon started walking towards him.

Mydei tensed. His hands curled into fists, though with no real target. He wasn’t ready for this. Not now.

Phainon stopped a few paces away, tilting his head slightly. *Observing*. Always observing.

“Mydei,” he said, voice infuriatingly level. “You’re scowling more than usual.”

“Must be the company,” Mydei shot back immediately, because instincts were the only thing keeping him functional at this point.

Phainon hummed, unimpressed. “If something’s bothering you, you could just say it.”

“I don’t waste my breath on pointless things.”

Phainon crossed his arms. “So you admit you’re *thinking* about something.”

Mydei resisted the urge to lunge for his sword. *Not because he was angry. Just because stabbing something sounded preferable to dealing with this conversation.*

“Don’t you have training to get back to?” he snapped.

Phainon smiled. Slight. Almost imperceptible. But *there*.

“I finished early,” he said. “Thought I’d see what had you brooding this time.”

Mydei turned away. He refused to engage with this.

The way Phainon watched him, measured and patient, as if he were waiting for something. The way he never pushed, but *lingered*.

Phainon’s been in love with you for years.

No.

Without a word, Mydei forced himself to move, to turn his back and start walking away.

This wasn’t real. This wasn’t happening. He had better things to think about. He had—

His thoughts flicked back—against his will—to the way Phainon had looked at him just now. And before he could stop himself, the word slipped out, too quiet for anyone to hear.

“Shit.”

It had begun.

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1. Denial

This wasn’t happening.

It simply was *not* happening.

Phainon was *not* in love with him. That was absurd. Beyond absurd. An insult to logic itself. A blatant, deliberate lie conjured by lesser minds who clearly had nothing better to do than fill the air with nonsense and hope it stuck.

For all he knew, Gaius had suffered a severe head injury and was now experiencing catastrophic cognitive failure. That was the only reasonable explanation.

Because the alternative?

The alternative was that Mydei—*Mydei*—had been *oblivious* to something so obvious that even the common civilians had figured it out before him.

No. Impossible. He would have noticed.

…Wouldn’t he?

Wouldn’t he?

He stalked through the corridors of Okhema, arms crossed, expression set in something so severe that every soldier in his path either turned away or stepped aside without a word. *Good*. He had no patience for fools right now.

Phainon. *In love with him.*

The more he thought about it, the more *insultingly* ridiculous it became.

Phainon wasn’t like that. He was Mydei’s rival—his equal in battle, his persistent shadow, the one person he could count on to *keep up with him*. The *only* person who could. Their relationship was built on steel and

strategy, an unspoken understanding honed over years of war and competition.

There was no room for… *for that.*

His jaw locked.

It was a misunderstanding. It *had* to be.

Perhaps Phainon admired him—yes, that made sense. Anyone with a shred of intelligence would recognize Mydei's strength and aspire to it. That was all it was. The fool had mistaken admiration for something it wasn't, and now half the city had lost its collective mind.

Or worse—perhaps *Phainon himself* had started believing their nonsense.

Yes. That was far more likely.

Phainon was gullible like that. Always taking people's words too seriously, always talking about *honor* and *duty* as if they weren't just pieces in the greater game of power. Someone must have whispered the idea into his ear so many times that he'd simply accepted it as truth.

It wasn't real.

Couldn't be real.

It made no sense.

And Mydei was not about to waste another second entertaining such an impossibility.

Decision made, he stopped in his tracks.

A nearby soldier flinched so violently it was almost impressive. Mydei ignored him.

This was beneath him. Utterly beneath him.

There was nothing to address. *Nothing* to acknowledge. *Nothing* to—

He spotted Phainon rounding the corner ahead.

Their eyes met.

And there it was.

That look.

The one Mydei had *forcefully* ignored for years. The one that lingered a fraction of a second too long, that softened ever so slightly at the edges. The one that, now that he'd *noticed*, he *couldn't* unsee.

And suddenly, with a certainty he despised, Mydei knew that if he didn't *leave immediately*, something unspeakable was going to happen.

Like acknowledging this absolute lunacy as anything other than falsehood.

So he did what any rational person would do when faced with a complete, undeniable falsehood.

He turned on his heel and walked the other way.

Phainon, still mid-step, blinked. "…Mydei?"

Mydei did not respond.

"Mydei." Phainon's voice carried the distinct note of someone who had never seen Mydei walk away from a fight before. "Are you—"

Mydei took the next turn at *twice* his usual pace.

He was *not* doing this today.

Not now.

Not ever.

This conversation didn’t exist. This possibility didn’t exist.

This was *not happening.*

And if he repeated that to himself enough times, perhaps one day, he’d even believe it.

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2. Anger

No. No, this was *unacceptable*.

Phainon was *not* in love with him.

Who even *thought* of such an idea?

For all the soldiers and officers marching around Okhema, surely *none* of them had anything better to do than to come up with these ridiculous stories. They’d all seen him and Phainon spar, seen them fight side-by-side, watched as they’d thrown themselves into battle time and again, testing each other’s limits, sharpening one another like two blades in a forge. There was no need to bring *that* into it.

But now—now, thanks to Gaius’ idiotic little announcement—*everyone* seemed to have a comment to make.

“I don’t understand,” muttered a voice from behind him, clearly too clueless to recognize the storm in Mydei’s posture. “I thought you and Phainon were —well, you know.”

Mydei’s head whipped around so fast that the man fell silent immediately.

He wanted to say something cutting, something sharp enough to make this whole *situation* go away, but his mind kept circling back to the same question: *Why in the hell did everyone think Phainon was in love with him?*

Because that made no sense.

No. Sense.

“Didn’t you notice?” The voice continued, oblivious to the fact that he was poking a dangerous bear. “He’s always around you. He looks at you like—”

The words were barely out before Mydei had turned on his heel again, heading straight for the open courtyard. His fists were clenched, his shoulders tight, his steps deliberate, quick.

The audacity.

The *absolute audacity* of this situation.

Who *did* these people think they were? And why—*why* had they felt the need to make everything so *obvious*?

Mydei’s eyes narrowed as he stomped through the courtyard. *Didn’t they understand?*

It wasn’t like he was blind. He’d noticed the glances. The soft expressions Phainon let slip when he *thought* Mydei wasn’t looking. But it wasn’t what they thought it was.

No. This wasn’t the beginning of some tragic romance novel. They were not two star-crossed lovers destined to get tangled in each other’s mess. *He wasn’t some innocent fool who’d wandered into this trap.*

But suddenly—thanks to the clumsy idiot who’d opened their mouth about it—everything seemed to be… *there*. In plain view. Like a broken sword held right under his nose.

Phainon wasn’t just some opponent anymore. He wasn’t just a rival, the one person who could hold his ground when it counted. Now, *every* single exchange between them was being seen through a completely different lens.

And it was enraging.

Because it was—*stupid*.

Why would Phainon waste his time on him? *Him*, of all people?

He was *Mydei,* damn it. He didn't have time for this nonsense. He had no interest in being anyone's muse, no desire to be swept into some overblown display of emotion. *He* was the one who decided who mattered. Not the other way around.

"I've had enough of this," he muttered, frustration bubbling up from somewhere deep in his chest.

Why? Why would anyone even *think* this? It was beyond him. He didn't have the patience to entertain this kind of absurdity.

And yet—*and yet*, he found himself searching the courtyard for Phainon, his irritation only growing with each passing second.

Surely he wasn't *actually* waiting for something to happen. Surely he wasn't hoping for Mydei to, what—look at him differently?

No. *No*.

Mydei wouldn't allow it.

With a harsh grunt, Mydei spun around again, forcing his way through the crowd of civilians who were going about their business, oblivious to the storm about to break in their midst.

He needed to focus.

He needed a *distraction*.

But the thing about anger was that it made everything else seem so insignificant. The world around him blurred, reduced to nothing more than shapes and noise as the pressure continued to build in his chest.

"Damn it, Phainon…"

His hands clenched tighter at his sides.

What was *wrong* with him?

No.

He wasn’t going to deal with this.

Not like this.

It was *stupid*.

It was beneath him.

He was going to handle it.

He *had* to handle it.

But as he marched forward, the nagging feeling was still there, unshakable, a dull ache behind his ribs. Because no matter how loudly he told himself otherwise, the truth lingered in his mind like a splinter he couldn’t remove.

Maybe he hadn’t noticed it.

Maybe he’d been blind to what had been in front of him for years.

But what did that *mean*?

Nothing.

It meant nothing.

He had more important things to think about than *this*.

And Phainon?

He could deal with this mess himself.

Mydei didn’t have time for any of it.

It was stupid.

It was *stupid*.

But, as he walked away, one thought kept gnawing at him.

What *if* it was true?

He didn’t continue that train of thought.

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3. Bargaining

Alright, okay. This was fine. This was manageable.

It wasn’t the end of the world, for the love of the gods.

There had to be a way out of this. *There had to be.*

Phainon wasn’t in love with him. That was the truth. *He wasn’t.*

But if he was? If there was even a shred of truth to this? Then fine. Maybe —just maybe—it could be… *corrected*.

Not that there was anything to correct. But maybe, just maybe, it could all go back to normal.

Mydei’s thoughts were racing now, each step he took in Okhema feeling like it reverberated with an unease he couldn’t shake off. He was too quick to dismiss this. He couldn’t just bury his head in the sand.

But that didn’t mean he had to admit anything out loud.

Sure, Phainon might have been acting strange—more strange than usual—but that didn’t mean it had to be this.

It was just—just—an odd misstep.

No one could blame him.

Okay, maybe he could blame Gaius for being a complete imbecile, for speaking out of turn, for—Gods—*ruining everything*.

But that didn’t matter. He could still work with this. He could still handle this.

“Right,” Mydei muttered to himself, his voice low and forceful as he strolled through the halls, eyes locked on the path ahead. “All I need to do is get him to—”

What?

What did he need to do, exactly?

How did you even fix something like this?

All these damn thoughts running in circles, making everything worse. It was like trying to fight the wind.

But fine. If there was any chance in the gods’ name that Phainon had developed *feelings*, maybe he could… do something.

He didn’t have to ruin everything, right? He could just set things straight.

“Alright. Alright. I’ll just—I’ll talk to him,” Mydei muttered, like saying the words aloud would somehow make the whole situation make sense. “Just clear the air. It’s not a big deal. Just tell him, ‘Hey, Phainon. You’ve misunderstood. I don’t… do that.’” He’s talking to himself now, surely he’s gone insane.

That wasn’t even a *sentence*—it was nonsense. But he needed to say it to ground himself, to stop the brain fog from taking over.

“Or maybe I’ll—no, no. That’s stupid. He can’t get attached. Just—just make it clear there’s no room for that, alright? No space for feelings.”

He paused as he reached the open training ground. Phainon was there, of course. Where else would he be?

He stood with his back to Mydei, talking to some of the other soldiers in that way he always did—like he had to be a model of *something*, even if it was the most irritating thing in the world. His movements were all casual,

but there was that little tick of energy in his posture, the way his shoulders never quite relaxed. Like he was waiting for something.

Mydei clenched his jaw. He could almost feel the unease radiating from the man. It was as if Phainon could sense the tension, too, though Mydei wasn't sure if that was actually possible. It didn't matter.

He could fix this. He just needed to get his words right.

"Alright," he muttered again, this time a bit louder, like he was trying to convince himself. "I'll just have a normal conversation. It'll be fine. I'll be like, 'Phainon, you've been a fool, and it's time to stop. There's no space for that nonsense here. We're brothers-in-arms, nothing more.'"

It sounded fine in his head, didn't it?

But then…

But then…

What if Phainon—*what if* he *didn't* stop? What if this foolishness continued, no matter how many times Mydei made it clear? What if this went on… forever?

What would he even *do* then?

The thought of spending the rest of his days battling with *that* unspoken tension—it was absurd. The frustration alone was enough to make Mydei want to tear down half the training grounds.

But no. He couldn't do that.

No, he was better than this. He was better than any of this nonsense.

Maybe… maybe he'd just have to *make* Phainon realize this wasn't real. Make him see that it was all a mistake.

That would work, wouldn't it?

Just… one conversation. One simple exchange. No drama, no grand speeches. Just the words he needed to set things right.

“Right?”

It was just… *that* simple.

It had to be.

The more he thought about it, the more ridiculous the idea of it seemed. What was he even saying? What was he trying to fix here?

Mydei scowled as he approached Phainon’s spot in the courtyard. There was that stupid calm look on Phainon’s face, like nothing had changed, like everything in the world was in its proper place. It made Mydei’s insides twist.

This—this couldn’t be how it ended. No. No way.

“Phainon,” he snapped. His tone was sharp, hard. “We need to talk.”

For a brief moment, Phainon’s expression softened, but only just. “About what, Mydei?”

And that was it. The words hung in the air. The weight of them, of the *idea* of them, was nearly suffocating.

“About… nothing.”

The words felt weak even as he said them. He hated himself for it.

No. No, he wasn’t going to back down. He had to fix this.

He would.

There was no other option.

But just not right now.

4. Depression

So this was it.

He couldn’t fix it. He couldn’t fix *any of it.*

Phainon’s eyes were still there in his mind, those stupidly soft eyes that had no right to be aimed in his direction. They lingered in every moment, like an unwelcome echo that refused to fade. The whole thing had grown so… absurd. He’d convinced himself he could handle it. He’d convinced himself he could turn it around. That was the game, right? Manipulate the situation to his will. Make the rules fit.

Except now?

He was trapped.

Mydei had tried to avoid it. He had—he really had.

He’d avoided confronting the fact that the whole thing was *not* going away. No amount of dismissing or pushing it to the back of his mind would make the reality fade. Phainon was still there, still *present*. And there was no way to break it without breaking the entire fabric of everything Mydei had come to rely on.

But none of that stopped him from feeling like a sinking ship.

None of it stopped the heavy weight that pressed into his chest every time he considered the situation in full.

That stupid voice in his head? It was *right*. Phainon had always been there. Always. Constantly. With that irritating, never-ending, stupid faith in Mydei.

And now?

Now, that faith was something more. Something dangerous. Something that *hurt*.

It wasn’t supposed to be this way.

Mydei’s boots echoed in the stone halls as he walked—no, *dragged*—his feet. He wasn’t even sure where he was going anymore. Wasn’t sure what the point was. He couldn’t think straight. Couldn’t get rid of that insistent pounding in his skull. He was supposed to be doing something, anything other than this.

He paused, leaning against a cold stone wall and staring down the empty hallway in front of him. His hand tightened around his arm. He could feel the weight of the world pressing down on him.

How had it gotten to this?

How had *he* gotten to this?

“I don’t—” Mydei muttered, words failing him. He squeezed his eyes shut. “This wasn’t supposed to happen. This isn’t how it works. This isn’t—this isn’t—”

He needed air.

He needed to breathe.

With a growl of frustration, he pushed himself off the wall and walked down the corridor. It didn’t matter where he went. He was just moving. He didn’t even care who saw him like this. The last few days had been a blur. A haze. All he could see now was Phainon’s face, always a little too close, always too patient, too understanding.

It was maddening.

No.

He wasn’t mad.

He was frustrated.

Angry, even.

At himself.

At Phainon.

At the gods for conspiring against him.

No one had warned him this would happen. No one had warned him about this.

And now?

Now he had no choice but to sit in it.

He wasn’t ready to admit that, though. Not yet. That would be the last straw, wouldn’t it?

If he acknowledged how much it was affecting him…

And the worst part was that it wasn’t even *his* fault.

It was just… *happening*.

Mydei’s eyes snapped open as he neared the entrance to one of Okhema’s many bakeries and restaurants. The smell of roasted meat, fresh bread, and herbs hit him all at once. It was the kind of smell that reminded him of home—before the crown, before the duty, before any of this had ever started. It had been a simpler time.

But there was no time for nostalgia.

He pushed open the door, the sound of it creaking breaking the silence. Inside, citizens were clustered around tables, laughing and eating, a few murmuring among themselves. Nothing worth caring about.

Except—

There.

Sitting at the far end of the table, Phainon was munching on a loaf of bread with his usual insufferable ease, as if nothing in the world could ever disturb his calm. He glanced up when Mydei entered, his gaze sharp and expectant.

For the first time in days, Mydei felt his stomach twist.

The heavy weight of it settled in his chest, and before he could stop himself, he was striding over to Phainon with a force he wasn't even aware he had.

"Hey," Mydei snapped, almost too harshly, and Phainon blinked at him, expression softening but cautious.

"Everything alright?" Phainon asked, voice steady as always.

No, Mydei wanted to shout. *Everything is not alright.*

But instead, he just… stood there.

And stared.

For a long moment, neither of them spoke.

And then, without warning, Mydei muttered, barely audible, "I don't know how to fix this."

Phainon, to his credit, didn't laugh. Didn't mock. He just gave him that look again, the same one that made Mydei want to crawl out of his own skin.

"Then… don't. Don't fix it."

"I can't—" Mydei started, but the words stopped in his throat, swallowed by something too big to ignore.

"You don't have to."

The simplicity of it almost broke him.

The weight of it. The way Phainon looked at him with that infuriating calm. It was everything Mydei couldn’t hold together anymore.

Maybe it wasn’t about fixing it. Maybe it was about the fact that nothing was ever going to change.

And Mydei was too exhausted to pretend otherwise.

“Not right now,” he muttered, turning on his heel and walking away.

It wasn’t right now. Not yet.

But *soon*.

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5. Acceptance

Alright. Fine.

Fucking *fine*.

This was happening. This was real. This was his life now.

Mydei sat alone in one of Okhema’s higher terraces, perched on the edge of the stone railing like some brooding tragic figure, staring out over the sprawling city below. The wind was crisp, the sky was clear, and everything was horribly, disgustingly peaceful. He should have been enjoying the quiet.

Instead, he was coming to terms with the fact that his greatest rival, the one person who could match him in strength, wit, and sheer *stubbornness*, had apparently been in love with him for years, and Mydei was… not as opposed to the idea as he should have been.

The last few days had been a mess of emotions he’d never had to deal with before. He had cycled through denial, rage, bargaining, and a brief but deeply humiliating spiral of melancholy. And after exhausting every possible alternative, he had finally arrived at the only conclusion left.

This was real. It was happening. And there was absolutely nothing he could do about it.

Phainon liked him.

And worse—so much worse—Mydei actually cared.

The realization sat heavy in his chest, an uncomfortable weight that he wasn't sure how to carry. Mydei had spent his whole life knowing exactly who he was, exactly what he wanted. He had a goal, a purpose, a reason for every action he took.

And yet, for the first time in years, he was faced with something that had nothing to do with battle, nothing to do with duty or strategy. Something that wasn't about winning or losing.

Something personal.

He hated it.

He hated how it made his thoughts wander, how it made his stomach twist in a way that wasn't unpleasant, but also wasn't normal. He hated that now, when he looked at Phainon, he saw more—more than a rival, more than a warrior, more than just another opponent to test himself against.

He hated that, deep down, he'd probably seen it all along.

Maybe he had always known. Maybe he had just refused to acknowledge it, because acknowledging it meant admitting something he wasn't ready to admit.

But he was ready now. Or at least, he was as ready as he was ever going to be.

A gust of wind cut through the terrace, rustling Mydei's hair, carrying the faint sounds of the city below. He exhaled sharply, pressing a hand to his forehead.

“Gods,” he muttered, letting his head tilt back against the stone. “This is so stupid.”

But it wasn’t, really. That was the worst part. It wasn’t stupid. It was just… terrifying.

Because Mydei wasn’t someone who did things halfway. He wasn’t someone who hesitated, who second-guessed, who walked into something without knowing exactly how it would end.

If he was going to do this—if he was going to accept this—then there was only one way forward.

And in the traditions of Castrum Kremnos, there was only one way to settle something as monumental as this.

A duel.

A declaration.

A challenge issued, and an answer given.

The thought should have made him nervous. It should have sent him spiraling all over again.

Instead, for the first time in days, Mydei felt steady.

This was something he could do. This was something he understood.

A fight. A win. A statement, made in the only language he knew how to speak.

Phainon had been waiting for him.

It was time to answer.

The marketplace was lively, bustling with vendors calling out their wares and the scent of freshly baked bread wafting through the air. Phainon

navigated through the crowd with ease, offering polite nods to those who recognized him. It was, for once, a peaceful afternoon—no battles, no pressing duties, no—

A shadow moved.

Phainon barely had time to register it before a gust of wind kicked up dust from the stone streets, and suddenly, Mydei descended from the rooftop above, landing in front of him with the grace of a blade being unsheathed.

A few people gasped. Someone dropped a basket of fruit.

Phainon blinked. “Mydei?”

Mydei straightened, golden eyes locked onto him with a level of intensity that suggested something either very serious or very stupid was about to happen.

Then, in a voice loud enough to carry over the entire market, he declared, “I challenge you.”

Silence.

The kind of silence that wasn’t actually silent at all—just filled with the sharp absence of noise, the way people stop mid-motion when something shocking happens.

Phainon tilted his head. “To what, exactly?”

“A duel.”

A few of the passing merchants gasped. Two Kremnos-born soldiers, who had been walking by with baskets of supplies, froze in place. One of them made a strangled sound in the back of his throat.

“Did he just—”

“Shh!” the other hissed, frantically slapping a hand over his companion’s mouth.

Phainon glanced between them, then back at Mydei. His rival—no, his friend—stood there, shoulders squared, hands steady, gaze sharp. There was something *definitive* about the way he carried himself, something final, like this wasn't just about a fight.

Phainon exhaled, giving Mydei a small, indulgent smile.

"…Alright."

The whispering exploded.

Phainon only caught fragments. *"Did he just—" "Is this really happening?" "But that means—" "He can't seriously—" "I mean, it is the Crown Prince—" "Someone go find—"*

None of it made sense.

Phainon glanced around, vaguely concerned. "…Did I just agree to something I don't understand?"

"Yes," someone muttered nearby.

Mydei, who had not looked away from him once, simply rolled his shoulders and took a step back. "We'll settle this properly."

And that was when Phainon realized, with absolute certainty, that he had no *idea* what was going on.

-

This was a mistake.

Phainon wasn't sure *how* it was a mistake, or *why* it was a mistake, but every instinct honed through years of battle screamed that he had, in fact, just walked directly into a disaster.

He barely had time to process it before Mydei moved.

It started with the sharp clang of metal—Mydei snapping his gauntlets into place, the mechanism locking over his hands like an executioner preparing his blade. Then, without a single wasted motion, he *lunged*.

Phainon's sword was halfway drawn before Mydei was on him, fists flashing as they struck against his hastily raised blade. The force of impact rattled down to his bones.

"Mydei—!" Phainon started, but Mydei did not seem remotely interested in conversation.

A second strike, heavier than the first, sent Phainon skidding back a step.

Right. No talking, then.

Phainon exhaled sharply, adjusting his stance. He'd fought Mydei more times than he could count—this wasn't new. What *was* new, however, was the sheer *ferocity* behind each strike. Mydei always fought with precision, but this was something else entirely.

Mydei was fighting like a man who had made a decision.

Phainon dodged a blow aimed at his ribs and tried again. "I don't suppose you'd like to explain why we're doing this in the middle of the market?"

A gauntleted fist slammed into his blade, forcing him back another step.

"Not particularly," Mydei replied, tone infuriatingly neutral.

Phainon gritted his teeth. "Are you *angry* at me?"

"No." Another strike. "You'd know if I was."

Phainon parried fast, shifting his weight to avoid being completely overpowered. He could hold his own, but Mydei was relentless.

"Then *what* is this?" he tried, ducking under a swing.

"A duel."

Phainon barely managed to stop himself from groaning. “Yes, I gathered that, thank you—”

He was cut off by a sudden, brutal downward strike. Phainon twisted away, landing in a crouch as Mydei’s gauntlet hit the stone where he had just been standing, leaving a *visible crack* in the ground.

Phainon inhaled sharply.

Alright.

Fine.

Clearly, talking wasn’t going to get him anywhere.

He’d just have to beat some answers out of Mydei instead.

Phainon adjusted his grip on his sword and surged forward. Mydei met him head-on, the force of their clash sending dust and scattered debris into the air. The market had long since cleared out—whether out of respect or self-preservation, Phainon wasn’t sure.

Mydei was fast, aggressive, leaving little room to breathe between strikes, but Phainon had fought him long enough to know his rhythms. He started pushing back, forcing Mydei to pivot, *sidestep*, adjust. It wasn’t much, but it was *enough*.

Then, finally, Phainon saw it—an opening.

Mydei had left his left side just a fraction too exposed. It was an instant, but an instant was all Phainon needed.

He moved.

Blade flashing, Phainon twisted past Mydei’s guard, drawing up to strike—

And then he saw it.

The shift. The way Mydei's stance changed, weight shifting, fingers tightening—

Shit.

Phainon had fallen for it.

Before he could even register the mistake, Mydei's gauntlet slammed into his ribs, knocking the wind out of him. Another hit caught his wrist, sending his sword flying.

Phainon barely had time to react before Mydei stepped in close, *far* too close, and with the force of someone who had absolutely, *unquestionably* made up his mind, grabbed a fistful of Phainon's hair and *yanked*.

Phainon barely had time to part his lips in protest before Mydei kissed him.

Hard.

It wasn't slow, wasn't gentle—wasn't anything *remotely* soft. It was raw, heated, and *definitive*, the way Mydei did everything: with full intent, full commitment, as if daring Phainon to question it.

Phainon, breath stolen, brain short-circuiting, barely had time to *register* what was happening before Mydei pulled back, golden eyes burning, licking the taste of the fight off his lips like it was something to be savored.

Phainon's heart was still racing, body still buzzing from the clash of steel and muscle and—

Oh.

Oh.

Phainon exhaled, the weight of realization slamming into him just as hard as Mydei had.

"Mydei," he managed, voice hoarse.

Mydei, of course, did not answer.

Instead, he turned sharply on his heel—silent, unwavering—and *walked away.*

Phainon stared after him.

"…What," he said, blankly.

He was going to need several minutes to process this.

Phainon had been hit with warhammers that rattled less than whatever the hell had just happened.

His lungs were on fire, his ribs ached in ways that made him question his life choices, and the taste of iron—mixed with something infuriatingly *Mydei*—lingered on his lips. His sword was abandoned somewhere on the ground, his hair still half-yanked from the grip Mydei had released him from, and most importantly…

Mydei.

Was.

Walking away.

Like that had been the most normal, reasonable conclusion to all of this.

"Wait." Phainon's voice cracked, more strangled than he intended, but it got the job done.

Mydei, to his credit, did pause. For a fraction of a second.

Then, without bothering to turn back, he said, as casually as if they were discussing the weather:

"I am declaring my intention to court you."

Silence.

A long, unbearable silence, broken only by the faint, shocked gasps of a few unfortunate bystanders who had stayed behind to witness this *disaster*.

Phainon blinked, certain he'd misheard.

"…You're what?"

Mydei finally stopped and faced him, his expression unreadable, as if this was something he had planned all along.

"You heard me."

Phainon did hear him. He simply did not understand him.

Mydei, utterly unbothered by the fact that Phainon was very clearly spiraling, went on with the same blunt confidence, as though this were a mere formality.

"I have bested you in combat," he said, as if the events of the last minute hadn't included a brutal fight and a kiss that nearly set Phainon's brain on fire. "That was the first requirement. The challenge."

Another strained silence.

Phainon felt his entire world shift under his feet.

Someone, somewhere in the crowd, gasped, "The Crown Prince really just —" before the words were swiftly smothered by a round of urgent shushing.

Phainon dragged both hands down his face, his mind struggling to catch up with his body's need to keep breathing.

He had agreed to a duel.

He had no idea he was apparently agreeing to the *first step* of Kremnian courting traditions.

"Mydei."

Mydei raised an eyebrow. “Phainon.”

“You’re telling me,” Phainon said, voice forced to remain painfully calm, “that I just unknowingly participated in my own *courtship*?”

“Yes,” Mydei replied, as if that were the most matter-of-fact thing Phainon had ever heard.

Phainon exhaled slowly, tilting his head back toward the sky, hoping the gods would grant him a moment of clarity.

He received none.

Instead, he looked back down to find Mydei still watching him, arms crossed, completely unfazed by the situation, as though waiting for Phainon to give him some kind of response.

Phainon let out a sharp breath, feeling his patience fraying.

“I see,” he said carefully, already knowing that he didn’t understand anything. “I understand.”

Mydei gave a single, satisfied nod.

Phainon nodded back, if only to appease the man.

Then, after a moment of careful consideration, he turned on his heel—and walked away.

“Mydei,” he called over his shoulder, voice too exhausted for what had just transpired. “Give me one moment.”

He needed a drink. Or five. And then, maybe, he’d be able to process any of this.

Maybe.

Phainon had barely made it three paces before Mydei called out to him, the words cutting through the air like a blade.

“Phainon!”

Phainon froze but didn’t turn around. The last thing he wanted was to face this now—whatever this was. But Mydei’s voice was insistent. There was no escaping it.

With a long, resigned sigh, Phainon finally turned around to face him, and Mydei—of course, *of course*—was standing there, as composed as ever, with the entirety of Okhema watching them.

The tension in the air could’ve suffocated a hundred men.

And yet, Mydei, that damned fool, didn’t care. His eyes locked on Phainon’s, his expression intense, almost pleading.

“I—” Mydei began, and for the first time, Phainon could see the flicker of something else in his gaze. Something raw. Something real.

“Mydei,” Phainon interrupted, almost too exhausted to care. “Please, for the love of all gods, not in public.”

But Mydei didn’t even flinch. Instead, he stepped forward, closing the space between them, and before Phainon could even blink, Mydei said the words that made his heart stop.

“Phainon, I—”

He paused, the weight of his next sentence palpable. The entire crowd had gone deathly silent, holding their breath as Mydei continued, voice deepening with each word.

“I love you.”

Silence.

Not just the usual pause, but a full, crashing silence, thick and suffocating. Even the birds had stopped singing.

Phainon blinked. Then blinked again, as if his brain hadn’t quite processed what had just happened.

“Wha—?”

But Mydei wasn’t finished.

“I’ve been an idiot,” he said, arms outstretched now, eyes intense, like a man on the edge of a cliff, daring Phainon to push him over. “I’ve spent so long trying to convince myself it wasn’t real. That this—this—was nothing more than some bizarre twist of fate. But it’s not. I—I care about you. And I’m sick of pretending that I don’t. You’re mine, Phainon. Whether you like it or not.”

The last words hung in the air, thick with emotion and expectation. The crowd was still as stone, too scared to even breathe, but Phainon? Phainon didn’t know what to do.

Was this some cruel joke? Some twisted play to make him lose what little dignity he had left?

“Mydei…” he began, voice hoarse. “This is—this can’t be real—”

But his words cut off abruptly as his body finally betrayed him, and he slumped forward, unconscious before he even hit the ground.

Phainon’s world went black.

It only took about three seconds for Phainon to pass out cold in Mydei’s arms. The sheer dramatic timing was impeccable, really.

Mydei caught him with little more effort than it would take to lift a sleeping dog. Of course, that didn’t make this any less ridiculous.

“Well, that’s one way to get out of awkward situations,” Mydei muttered, staring down at the man draped across him like a dead weight—no, more like a *ridiculously* heavy coat that had fallen asleep mid-conversation.

He sighed.

This wasn’t how it was supposed to go. Sure, he’d been hoping for some kind of grand reaction, but… *this*? This wasn’t even a response. This was just Phainon deciding to skip the rest of the conversation and go straight into nap mode.

For a moment, Mydei considered just leaving him there in the middle of the market, like some kind of public spectacle. But no, that wasn’t quite dramatic enough. Besides, Phainon was his idiot to deal with now.

So, with a grunt, Mydei hoisted Phainon up in a single smooth motion.

“I’m just gonna take you home,” he said, completely unbothered by the fact that he was carrying a fully grown man like a child. “And you’re not going to remember any of this, are you?”

There were no protests—only the soft sound of Phainon’s unconscious breathing as Mydei began marching through the marketplace. The crowd parted like the Red Sea, people scrambling to get out of the way. He could hear hushed whispers behind him, but he didn’t care.

It was clear the entire city had just watched their Crown Prince declare his love to a man, get kissed senseless, and then watch that man pass out cold before being effortlessly carted away like some kind of oversized sack of potatoes.

“Great,” Mydei muttered to himself, his voice dripping with sarcasm. “Just great. How did I end up in this absurd situation?”

He should’ve been embarrassed. He should’ve been furious. But honestly? The whole thing was just too ridiculous.

When they finally reached Phainon’s estate, Mydei kicked open the door like he owned the place—because, at this point, why not? He was already carrying Phainon like a prize he hadn’t even realized he’d won.

There were no grand speeches. No romantic declarations. Just Mydei, holding Phainon in his arms like it was a perfectly normal Tuesday. He gently laid Phainon down on a couch with more care than he'd like to admit, and then—*finally*—he sighed.

"That went… better than expected," Mydei said dryly, but then his eyes softened.

"Or not."

But honestly? He'd deal with the consequences later. Right now, he was just going to enjoy the chaos of it all. Because this was Phainon's problem now.

And maybe, just maybe, Mydei would actually figure out how to *talk* about his feelings next time—*without* Phainon passing out.

The next day came with the kind of awkward tension Mydei was *never* comfortable with. He hadn't been able to shake the nagging anxiety in his gut since he left Phainon's estate. For some inexplicable reason, Phainon hadn't woken up. Mydei had spent half the night pacing around, trying not to overthink the *slightly* over-the-top sequence of events. But now? Now, he was just worried.

The anxiety was doing wonders for his mood.

So, naturally, Mydei did what any sensible, highly emotionally intelligent person would do in this situation—he went to the training grounds to take out his frustration on the nearest person who wasn't Phainon. That person, unfortunately, was Gaius.

It started off as a standard sparring match, but quickly escalated into Mydei systematically dismantling Gaius with the precision of someone who had absolutely no other outlet for his frustrations.

"Is this really necessary?" Gaius wheezed from his spot on the ground, looking up at Mydei as he loomed over him like some kind of vengeful god.

“Yes.” Mydei’s voice was flat. “Now shut up and take your beating like a man.”

“You’re the one beating me, Mydei!” Gaius yelled, hands raised in defense, but Mydei wasn’t listening. He was too busy thinking about Phainon and how much he wanted to slap some sense into himself for letting *that* situation get so out of hand.

But just as Mydei wound back for what would undoubtedly be the most satisfying punch of his life, someone caught his fist mid-air.

Before he could even register what was happening, the person twisted his arm and yanked him toward them.

“Mydei.” The voice was low, steady, and unmistakably Phainon’s.

Phainon.

Mydei froze, but not because of the shock of his sudden appearance. No, he froze because Phainon’s grip on him was… a little more intense than expected, and he was being dragged toward a nearby alleyway with that same, determined look Phainon always wore when he had a goal in mind.

It wasn’t subtle.

There was no question about it now. Mydei’s stomach dropped as Phainon didn’t even glance back at him, just pulled him forward with a quiet urgency that had Mydei’s heart doing something resembling a backflip.

“Oh.” Mydei said intelligently.

Phainon didn’t answer, not that he needed to. His intentions were as clear as the sunlight overhead.

And then there was Gaius, still lying on the ground and blinking up at the sky in disbelief.

From his position, he had seen the entire exchange. From the point Mydei was about to knock him into the dirt, to the moment Phainon casually

appeared and stopped him, to *that* look in Phainon's eyes as he dragged Mydei off.

Gaius could only groan to himself and mutter under his breath.

"I knew it," he said, voice full of resigned amusement. "I fucking *knew* it."

And as he lay there, nursing the bruises Mydei had kindly gifted him, he couldn't help but wonder if the rest of Okhema was about to get an education in the kind of chaos that followed these two around.

Well, whatever. It wasn't his problem anymore.

End Notes

I think I have a thing for unexpected kisses but whatever. Anyway, what’d you guys think of this? Hope you liked it❤❤😘😘

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!